



Volunteer Ron Clark of the Carolina Raptor Center releases an eagle, believed to be about 6 months old, into the wild on Friday at the Alligator River National Wildlife Refuge. The eagle sustained injuries to both of its wings, and several surgeries were required to repair the injuries.

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'THERE SHE GOES'

After two months of rehabilitation in Charlotte, a young bald eagle is set free



The rehabilitated eagle

By CATHERINE KOZAK
The Virginian-Pilot

THE BALD EAGLE LOOKED ANGRY. Its talons curled in a sort of raptor fist, straining to strike the man holding its legs in one hand and its neck firm against his chest.

"No biting!" Ron Clark, a 16-year veteran volunteer at the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte, said teasingly to the bird, whose wide-open beak made its intentions clear.

With an unobstructed farm field in Alligator River National Wildlife Refuge serv-

ing as a perfect takeoff area Friday morning, Clark readied the young eagle to fly free for the first time since its two-month rehabilitation.

"She's quite stunning, isn't she?" Clark said, admiring the mostly brown bird, which glared back. The distinctive yellow in the bird's eyes and beak and the white in its head and tail won't show up for about three years.

Clark, protected by leather gloves lined with the same material used in bulletproof

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Volunteer Ron Clark of the Carolina Raptor Center removes the eagle from a kennel to be released into the wild on Friday. The eagle sustained injuries to both of its wings.

EAGLE

NORTH CAROLINA HAS ABOUT 100 ACTIVE NESTS

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vests, thrust his arms in the air and let go. The eagle spread its 6-foot wings, caught the wind and took to the sky. Gaining altitude, it pumped its wings in majestic strokes and glided toward the north, and then banked east along the tree line.

"There she goes," he said to a handful of onlookers.

A long moment of silence followed as everyone watched the eagle's powerful wings carry it seemingly effortlessly toward the trees.

"I'd say she flies OK," Clark said with satisfaction.

As the raptor approached the forest, a slew of crows suddenly filled the sky in pursuit.

"It's called mobbing," Clark said. "She's not supposed to be here, so they're running her off."

Brought to the raptor center on May 28, the 6-month-old bald eagle had been spotted in April on the beach in Rodanthe, said refuge biologist Dennis Stewart.

"It was sitting out on the dune line, and appeared to be injured," he said. "We went out there with a net. It kept flying away from us."

Stewart said that after trying to catch to bird for about two weeks — although weak, it could still fly enough to escape — he finally went home and built a noose net to trap it. Lured by bait, the bird walked onto the device, and its feet were entrapped in the carpet of knotted lines.

The animal's wings were injured, and it was thin. Stewart



The eagle flies off on Friday shortly after being released.

took it to Dr. Mark Grossman, a Manteo veterinarian who treats wildlife. It was later transported in a large, padded dog kennel to a local wildlife rehabilitator, and then to the center in Charlotte.

Mathias Engelmann, the center's director of rehabilitation, said that the bird's cuts were on the leading edges of the wings, apparently from an accident.

"Young birds are inexperienced. They crash into things," he said. "It took a while to get her into shape."

Although the wings were not broken, several surgeries were required to repair the injuries. The bird then had to practice flying in a 100-foot flight cage.

Engelmann said that despite the clumsy ways of eagle adolescents, they rarely find their way to the center, which was started in the 1970s. About 5,000 hawks and owls have been released, but only 36 eagles.

"That tells you how rare they still are in the Carolinas," he said.

Engelmann said that the talons of the 10-pound eagle are so powerful that if they

closed down on something, it would take two adult men to open them up. That's why only trained people can handle eagles.

"You only get one chance," he said. "If you mess up, you're going to the hospital."

Once on the endangered species list, the nation's symbol of freedom is still protected, but its population is considered recovered.

There about 100 active eagle nests in North Carolina, each with one to three young. About 18 of those nests are in the Alligator River refuge. In comparison, South Carolina has about 250 nests and Alaska has thousands. In the wild, eagles live about 25 years; in captivity, they can live to 40.

If all goes well, Engelmann said, the released eagle, which is banded, may make a home at Alligator River, or it may continue its wanderings.

"There's no way to predict," he said. "Hopefully, we'll never hear from it again. No news is good news, as they say."

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